

The “AI Water/Energy Consumption” problem is one of capitalism/big corpos, not really of AI, and its not a tiny problem either.

Posted by u/Akumu9K • 0 points • 24 comments

There is nothing in this world I despise more than being like “Ummmm ackshtualllyyyyy both sides have a point!!11111”, but guess I have to fucking do this.

Both pro AI and anti AI arguments about this issue are fucking insane and just plain wrong in most cases, I feel like.

Yall, this is a problem that has nothing to do with AI. AI is just another money cow for big corpos to milk the shit out of, they have done that with other stuff plenty of times before, they will continue to do so afterwards. This is not a problem innate to AI. While AI is indeed another thing to cause this, and does exacerbate this problem, it is not the root cause. This is a problem of big corporations and capitalism, not of AI, and its honestly stupid to act like AI is the root of all evil.

But conversely, this problem is still real and does exist. Closed loop cooling still has pollution problems, such as heat pollution which can wreck ecosystems, and the energy usage is indeed an issue, not to mention the fact that the facilities which these AI's are ran on tend to be overall negatives for the human communities they affect aswell. It is stupid to say that this issue just doesnt exist and all is fine and dandy with AI.

I know alot of people arent so stupid that they argue idiotic points like these. To those people, thank you. But there is also alot of people who do, and for you, please just fucking stop. Your enemy is not AI, your enemy is not anti AI fuckers, your enemy is big corpos that are fucking this planet over. AI or not, these corporations are the problem, and have always been the problem.

The path to a better future lies not in our value judgements of tools that can be commandeered to serve good OR bad purposes, but it lies in humans, both the humans that have to make good choices and use their critical thinking to analyze things and find solutions, and also in the humans that are greedy little shits and fuck everything up and need to be stopped.

Comments

u/CozmikCardinal • 1 points • 2025-10-29 22:14 UTC

In my opinion, peoples underlying hate or distaste for capitalism is what is materializing when they rail against AI as it is in the US. Most of the time people don't realize it or just outright refuse to acknowledge it. A competent country that doesn't put profit over its people would have restrictions and guidelines in place that hold these AI companies accountable. You know Billionaires love another reason for everyone else to fight each other instead of them too.

u/mf99k • 1 points • 2025-10-29 06:37 UTC

I've kind of tried to explain this to my anti friends. I have a lot of issues with how data centers are being built, but if you really run the numbers, I probably use more water per day using the bathroom than I do on ai prompts every month. A lot of modern luxuries are terrible for the environment (cruise ships alone are atrocious polluters), and many art forms are bad for the environment as well. Spray paint was temporarily banned due to the CFCs in it being a significant contributing factor to the hole in the ozone layer. Life on this planet would effectively die out without the ozone layer. Enough campaigning was done to find an alternative to CFCs,

and spraypaint is somewhat safer now (despite being full of acetone and other carcinogens), but the point still stands that ai generated media is not the only form of entertainment that's been a massive danger to the environment.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-10-28 11:56 UTC

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u/MysteriousPepper8908 • 8 points • 2025-10-28 04:31 UTC

There just isn't data to show that AI or data centers in general are having a significant impact on overall energy use or contributing to pollution on a large scale. Centrism based on feels is hard to resist but if the data isn't there, it isn't there. Now, can it have negative localized effects? Yes, and we should be talking about where these data centers are being built but even most antis have abandoned AI being a serious environmental threat because there just isn't any evidence to support it other than a lot of people use it and it uses electricity so it must be a major contributor to these problems but that's just not supported by any hard evidence.

u/M1L0P • 1 points • 2025-10-28 12:08 UTC

We don't have hard data but we can certainly see where the data we do have is pointing towards. Ignoring the data we do have to claim "well it isn't conclusive yet" seems disingenuous.

An interesting read:

<https://news.mit.edu/2025/explained-generative-ai-environmental-impact-0117>

u/Browser1969 • 1 points • 2025-10-28 14:05 UTC

We've been over that stuff a thousand times since January, when that article was published and many more times in total. It's extremely disingenuous in the first place unless you argue for giving up on technology and going back to nature.

A ChatGPT query may consume 5 times the energy of a Google search but that's a problem only if you assume that people use ChatGPT for queries that a simple Google search would answer (hint: they use ChatGPT to get better answers than hours of manual lookups). Training AI to solve all sorts of problems extremely fast is only an issue if you assume that training humans and then putting them to work for years is somehow more efficient. Increasing data center power usage is only a problem if you believe that the average home or business is more concerned with energy efficiency, because people *will* consume the computing power in one way or another (hint: everyone else, except data centers, is way more concerned with upfront costs and with squeezing more computing speed at the cost of disproportional increase in energy consumption out of their local devices).

u/M1L0P • 1 points • 2025-10-28 14:19 UTC

I don't think that argument holds much water. Yes in the core energy consumption is going to increase. However that does not mean that all increases of energy consumption are not to be worried about.

Imagine I invented a way for people to do their dishes with less manual labor. Sure that's a great thing if it takes a similar amount of energy. Now what if it cost twice the amount of energy (maybe still worth it) or imagine even 100 times the amount. I'm sure you would agree that at some point that technology creates more problems than it solves.

Going back to AI. Yes it consumes more energy which is not inherently a problem. But we need to try and weigh the value it creates for the average person against the environment impact it will have on the average person.

On top of that you have an asymmetry where the people using the AI create advantages for themselves while the society as a whole bears the cost of climate change. That is of course a problem with many things but AI has a unique potential to exponentially grow that gap. Especially when companies start to operate more and more on them generating value for the few while offloading the environmental cost to everyone else

u/Akumu9K • 3 points • 2025-10-28 04:33 UTC

"...But even most antis have abandoned AI being a serious environmental threat" I spent HALF of my damn post arguing that AI isn't the main culprit here and it's the fact that companies don't give a fuck, can anybody here please read my post properly 🤔

I never argued it was a major contributor, I merely argued that it was another problem in the plethora of others, and that it has bad localized effects that can be easily mitigated if AI companies weren't so shit.

u/MysteriousPepper8908 • 3 points • 2025-10-28 04:40 UTC

Yes, I'm familiar with the adage that it's a capitalism problem, not an AI problem but that implies it's a problem when it really isn't in any major way. It's not a question of who's to blame but whether there is any blame to begin with and there isn't if it's not having the deleterious effects some people claim. The localized effects are real but the global effects really aren't or they're at least so far down the list that moaning about them while ignoring the far more significant contributions from so many things we do in daily life is disingenuous. It's not that people don't understand your point, it's just not a particularly valid point.

u/Akumu9K • 1 points • 2025-10-28 04:44 UTC

Well, yeah. There's a lot bigger problems out there and the global effects of AI kinda don't really exist. But uhhhh, this is not the "Discuss harmful effects of rare earth mineral extraction" subreddit, this is the "Discuss AI" subreddit, and people talk about the harmful effects of AI, which still does exist, mostly at the local level of course, but those do matter too.

I didn't exactly mean to make this point in support of or against anyone, so I don't get why it isn't valid to make, when it is independent of arguments such as "Well AI is bad!" "But other worse stuff exists and you contribute to that!"

u/MysteriousPepper8908 • 2 points • 2025-10-28 04:54 UTC

My toaster also uses energy, is that an issue that needs to be brought to the forefront for debate? No, because it's an insignificant contribution and so too is AI. Just because this is an AI sub doesn't mean I'm going to concern myself with non-issues.

If you want to talk local impacts, I support regulations to limit where data centers can be built but unfortunately that's one of about 1000 things that are being mismanaged in my country and there is only so much that can be done if those in power don't care. So we're agreed on that but that is really the only major factor worth considering here.

Whataboutism is a problem but there's a limit to what is sensible in the same way I'm not going to take you seriously if you blame the poor for our economic situation because you heard about a guy one time that committed welfare fraud. I'm not saying it didn't happen but to put the focus on that when it's such a small contributor indicates you're ideologically motivated and not operating in good faith.

u/Akumu9K • 2 points • 2025-10-28 05:01 UTC

Okay yeah I see where you are coming from, that's fair enough. Although, I still feel like my general point stands, in that the main problem is corporations, regardless of whether it's with AI or not. It's just dumb to say that AI is the problem when it's pretty easy to see that AI is just a tool and it's the companies that make horrible decisions that cause these problems, but it also seems to me like some people kinda just deny that these companies cause any problems in general, though that might be a me thing / skewed perspective / lack of data.

Also about AI harm, I feel like the harm it can cause to people might be a bigger issue then, but that's a rather complicated issue that I do not want to touch on fully rn, and it's also tangential to this debate, since this is about environmental impacts and whatnot. I just thought I'd mention it since you made me wonder.

u/MysteriousPepper8908 • 1 points • 2025-10-28 05:07 UTC

Oh, I think Meta and X particularly create plenty of problems in many other areas and social media is a much bigger polluter and energy user than AI so as a whole, it's not

great and AI induced psychosis is a fairly rare but still worthwhile concern given that a <1% rate of these problems is a lot when you have a billion weekly users. There are valid concerns to be had about AI economically and socially so I'd prefer to see that be the focus and furthermore for the focus to be on realistic solutions rather than pretending putting the genie back in the bottle and not making any further progress is a viable option at this point.

u/Akumu9K

• 3
points
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2025-10-28
05:12
UTC

Yeah
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true,
thank
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AI or whatever.
I mean, we
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And
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and
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and it
might
be a
better
idea
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tackle
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alongside
all the
other
environmental
problems

from other practices that corporations do, while certain stuff, like the social effects of AI, are unique to AI

u/Elven77AI • 3 points • 2025-10-28 04:21 UTC

If Elon Musk burning coal to power his datacenters defines AI, then Chinese paper/paint factories poisoning Yangtze must be the face of art.

u/Akumu9K • 1 points • 2025-10-28 04:23 UTC

I dont remember my post supporting non AI companies? I explicitly said the problem was big corporations. Why do you think I am hating on AI with this post? This is the kind of bullshit that prompted me to make this post in the first place, thanks for showing me that I was not wrong in doing so.

u/Elven77AI • 1 points • 2025-10-28 04:32 UTC

AntiAI defines AI as consisting solely of open-loop water-cooled, coal-burning monstrosities powered by corporate greed and disdain for environment, so their pro-Art position must be solely about the toxic cancer-village adjacent Chinese factories producing the art supplies/equipment they fetishize so much.

u/Akumu9K • 1 points • 2025-10-28 04:34 UTC

Yeah sure, thats a fair argument to make I guess, but like... My post was calling out that stuff too, I dont know what prompted you to go that route on this post 🤔

u/No-Bag-1628 • 1 points • 2025-10-28 04:10 UTC

What does 'big corpos' have to do with cooling needing water?

If you want to use AI, you need water to cool the processors it runs on. the size of the company doesn't change this fact.

u/Akumu9K • 1 points • 2025-10-28 04:12 UTC

You dont necessarily need water for cooling if you are running a closed loop, plus, the problem with big corpos is the fact that they dont really care about using water from a place that wont be wrecked by that usage, and dumping their heat in a place that wont be wrecked by it either.

Cooling solutions that dont fuck up the environment already exist, but they are more expensive, and take more time. That gets in the way of profits.

u/M1L0P • 1 points • 2025-10-28 12:10 UTC

You need energy to cool the water. And the heat has to go somewhere which also has big environmental implications.

u/No-Bag-1628 • -1 points • 2025-10-28 04:15 UTC

So... don't use AI? Like, if you have a problem with Big Corpo AI using so much water, boycott it until an option that is more environmentally friendly comes out.

u/Akumu9K • 1 points • 2025-10-28 04:18 UTC

Yeah we should boycott AI companies but like- Options that are environmentally friendly already exist. Its not that its technology we dont have, its that these companies care more about profits than the lives of people and the environment.

I mean, if nothing else, cooling towers exist, which bypass the heat pollution problem by dumping

the heat into the atmosphere where it can radiate out into space with convection fairly fast.
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cooling_tower

u/Radiant_Reception792 • 1 points • 2025-10-28 11:01 UTC

I don't think it using up water (which it doesn't use too much, a 100 word answer uses on average a third of a teaspoon) is that big of a problem, even if it uses gigantic amounts, if it's just build somewhere where that water can be supplied without putting too much pressure on the environment and the communities

u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2025-10-28 03:41 UTC

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